

Player and Windows Internet Explorer, all the software that we used to get bundled earlier is now gone. No Windows Mail, no Movie Maker, no Meeting Space, no Messenger, no DVD Maker, no Photo Gallery... nothing! We discover that we need another 173 MB download in the form of Windows Live Essentials to get anything at all working. Forget an office suite; you'll have to pay Microsoft close to Rs 17,000 to lay your hands on one. Or settle for a feature stripped one at Rs 5,000. That's still a lot. Simple CD burning can be done with Windows Explorer, but no Authoring (VCDs, Video DVDs and Audio CDs) and no ISO burning. And wait till you hear this: Windows Live still doesn't have a DVD Maker, and its Movie Maker is dysfunctional, at best.

Mandriva is aeons ahead. It includes a complete office suite, with more functionality than MS Office 2003. It's got the best audio player known to mankind, by the name of Amarok. A serious video player is lacking, but SMPlayer can be gotten from the repos. It has Kopete (instant messenger), KDenLive (a video editor), Gwenview (a photo viewer), The GIMP (an image composer with the same functionality as Photoshop, even with proper CMYK support) and a whole load of other software. Space consumption? A mere 2.5 GB when first installed.

So how can a 4.34 GB DVD install only 2.5 GB of software? Well, apart from KDE, the DVD holds another completely different set of applications for the GNOME environment. Apart from that, Mandriva can perform as a complete server. It actually has server packages for the Web, mail, database and DNS right on the DVD. Windows 7 does have IIS7, but it's stripped, and none of the additional server software is present. And there's also virtualisation and clustering software, and a full range of development software—from languages to IDEs.

Ratings	Windows: 3	Mandriva: 9
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Resource hogs

Windows 7 is a resource hog. It needs so much for itself that it leaves nothing else for others. With 2 GBs of RAM, we find only 427 MBs free for use. Just to display the desktop, it's been hogging graphics resources (I can tell from

the temperature of our GPU; in Windows XP it remains cool as anything, in Mandriva even cooler but on Windows 7 I can actually feel the heat radiating). With its new DirectX 11, it's touted as a gamer's OS. If I were to buy Windows 7 for gaming, I'd throw the disk into the sewers without remorse.

Mandriva on the other hand is based on Linux, and Linux has always been a low-requirements kernel. Compare the requirements: Windows 7 needs at least a GB of RAM, a good GPU and a 1GHz processor. Mandriva needs 256 MB of RAM, any old GPU which has worked in the history of UNIX and a 500MHz processor. And don't be fooled by these low requirements; Mandriva certainly offers a good user experience.

And as of now, Windows 7 is downloading more than 700 MBs of updates for itself and Office 2007.

Ratings	Windows: 4.5	Mandriva: 9
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Multimedia capabilities

Both Windows and Mandriva play MP3s and MP4 (XviD) files by default. Both play DVDs as well, and none play FLVs. Mandriva has an edge, however, as codecs for unsupported media formats are automatically downloaded and installed the first time you play one of those formats, whereas in Windows you need to trudge for a third-party solution that breaks the default codecs most of the time.

Ratings	Windows: 8.5	Mandriva: 9
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Bug hunting...

In Mandriva, we could not find a single road-blocking bug. However, Windows was full of them. First, Windows 7 would not recognise any drive volume labels I'd assigned to the disks and showed all of them as "Local Disk". In Contacts, you can create only those contacts that have birthdays in the future. This bug's been there since Vista. Then, in Windows Explorer, if you select multiple files, all the icons overlap together and create a hotchpotch in the preview pane.

